Question ID f5aa5040

Assessment	Test	Domain	Skill	Difficulty
SAT	Math	Advanced Math	Nonlinear equations in one variable and systems of equations in two variables	

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In the *xy*-plane, a line with equation $2y = c$ for some constant c intersects a parabola at exactly one point. If the parabola has equation $y = -2x^2 + 9x$, what is the value of c?

ID: f5aa5040 Answer

Correct Answer:
20.25, 81/4

Rationale

The correct answer is $\frac{81}{4}$. The given linear equation is $2y = c$. Dividing both sides of this equation by 2 yields $y = \frac{c}{2}$. Substituting $\frac{c}{2}$ for y in the equation of the parabola yields $\frac{c}{2} = -2x^2 + 9x$. Adding $2x^2$ and $-9x$ to both sides of this equation yields $2x^2 - 9x + \frac{c}{2} = 0$. Since it's given that the line and the parabola intersect at exactly one point, the equation $2x^2 - 9x + \frac{c}{2} = 0$ must have exactly one solution. An equation of the form $Ax^2 + Bx + C = 0$, where A, B, and C are constants, has exactly one solution when the discriminant, $B^2 - 4AC$, is equal to 0. In the equation $2x^2 - 9x + \frac{c}{2} = 0$, where $A = 2$, $B = -9$, and $C = \frac{c}{2}$, the discriminant is $(-9)^2 - 4(2)\left(\frac{c}{2}\right)$. Setting the discriminant equal to 0 yields $(-9)^2 - 4(2)\left(\frac{c}{2}\right) = 0$, or $81 - 4c = 0$. Adding $4c$ to both sides of this equation yields $81 = 4c$. Dividing both sides of this equation by 4 yields $c = \frac{81}{4}$. Note that 81/4 and 20.25 are examples of ways to enter a correct answer.

Question Difficulty:
Hard